

Student Name: Andrew

Typio Setting

Visual Settings									
Font Size: Medium	Font Style: Roboto	Font Color: grey-blue	BG Color: White	Accessory Color: Pink		Selection Color: Invert			
Subtitles: Off	Visual Keyboard: On	Highlight: On	Visual FX: On	Visual Hands: Flat Blue		Hands Style: Clear			
Audio Settings									
Voice: Default		Voice Rate: Medium		Voice Pitch: Medium		Keypress: Read		SFX: Default	
App Settings									
Accuracy Goal: 80	WPM Goal: 10	Smart WPM: On	Goal Lock: Off	Setting Lock: Off	Game Lock: Off	Typing Pet Coins: 0	Spell Mode: Off		
Short Lessons:									

Typio History

Lesson	Date	WPM	ACC	ERR
Average		3	86	0
1. J and F keys	04/09/24	4	100%	0
01. Letters A and B	04/09/24	1	66%	11
01. The Right Hand	04/16/24	3	84%	10
02. The Left Hand	04/30/24	3	85%	11
01. The Right Hand	09/16/24	2	78%	15
01. Letters A and B	09/16/24	2	78%	6

Typio Custom Lessons

Lesson name	Data
-------------	------

Quick Cards Setting

Visual Settings

Font Size: Medium	Font Style: Roboto	Font Color: grey-blue	BG Color: White	Accessory Color: 255, 0, 120	Selection Style: Invert	Subtitles: 600	Visual FX:
----------------------	-----------------------	--------------------------	--------------------	------------------------------------	----------------------------	-------------------	------------

Audio Settings

Voice: Default	Voice Rate: Medium	Voice Pitch: Medium	SFX: Default
----------------	--------------------	---------------------	--------------

App Settings

Setting Lock: Off	Deck / Test Editor Lock:
-------------------	--------------------------

Quick Cards History

Name	Percent	Incorrect	Missed Cards	Date
------	---------	-----------	--------------	------

Quick Cards Decks

Deck Name	Cards
Demo Deck	0

Quick Cards Tests

Test Name	Q"s
Demo Test	Samurai`Uses a single timed keypress`Teaches basic menu navigation`Requires input memorization`*Teaches resource management and planning Samura`*Gives us a single timed key press. Samura Canteen mkdjbrfn `*eruihjtgef

Arcade Setting

Visual Settings

Font Size: Medium	Font Style: Roboto	Font Color: 0, 0, 8	BG Color: Flat White	Accessory Color: 255, 0, 120	Wizards Tower SFX:	Samurai Flash:	Echo Arrows:
----------------------	-----------------------	------------------------	-------------------------	------------------------------------	-----------------------	-------------------	-----------------

Visual FX:

Audio Settings			
Voice: Default	Voice Rate: Medium	Voice Pitch: Medium	Music Volume:
App Settings			
Setting Lock:			

Arcade History

Name	Date
------	------

Hangryman

Task	Data
------	------

Pro Pack Setting

Visual Settings						
Font Size: 100	Font Style: Roboto	Font Color: grey-blue	BG Color: White	Accessory Color: 255, 0, 120	Subtitles: 600	Visual FX: On
Audio Settings						
Voice: Default	Voice Rate: Medium	Voice Pitch: Medium				

Reader Files

Title	Data
Decoding Lesson 10	1. thousand leaving roared waited cheered first while these crash leaned right proud reared afraid sharp 2. records nurse put watched turn voice shy awake worry brakes catcher's dollars hospital mixed driver closer strapped showed lonely onto two alive exhibition fist shake cast woman booing foot open people 3 Things Take a Baa Turn Art was standing on the pitcher's mound. His hands felt cold. The fans were yelling and booing because he had dropped the ball. The catcher yelled to him, "Come on, Art. Just zip it right in here." He pounded his fist into his mitt. Art stared at that mitt. He stared and stared. "Look at that mitt," he told himself. Now he was thinking the right way again. He said, "I'm going to zip that ball right into the mitt." He leaned back and shot the ball at the catcher's mitt. The batter didn't have time to start his swing . The catcher was on his seat. 33 "Strike one," the umpire called. [2] The fans began to say, "Did you see that?" Then the fans fell silent as Art reared back for his next pitch. "Zip--pow." Down went the catcher again. "Strike

Title	Data
	two." "Wow!" the fans yelled. Then they waited for Art's next pitch. Again Art heaved the ball so hard that the batter did not have time to swing. "Strike three. You're out." The fans clapped and cheered. Art struck out the next batter with three pitches. [1] The last batter took a swing at Art's fast ball, but he missed it by a foot. As Art walked from the pitcher's mound, all of the fans were standing and clapping. The players from the Tigers and the Reds came out to shake hands with him. Art felt proud. "Just think," he said to himself. "Last year, I was lonely and shy. But look at me now. I'm a star." And he was a star. That night his dad showed him the paper. There was a story about Art and his pitching. "I'm proud of you, Art," his dad said. [1] People from the big league came over to talk to Art that night. A man from the Reds said that he would pay Art three hundred thousand dollars if Art left school and became a pitcher for the Reds. A woman from the Tigers told Art that she would give Art five hundred thousand dollars if Art played with the Tigers. 34 Art told them that he would have to think about leaving School. Then some of Art's friends came over. They wanted to take Art to a party. Art asked his dad and mom, and they said that it was all right for him to go. [1] So Art got in the car. The driver zipped down the road from Art's farm. He went faster and faster. "This car is very fast," he told Art. Art did not like to go fast, but Art didn't want the other kids to think that he was afraid. So he didn't say anything. The car roared down the road. Just then a truck turned onto the road. The driver hit the brakes. The car began to slide. It slid to the left, and then it went back to the right. Nobody said a thing. They just watched the car come closer and closer to the truck. Closer. Closer. [1] When Art opened his eyes, he was looking at a green wall. He started to move. Then he saw that he was strapped into a bed. He felt a sharp pain in his arm. His arm was in a cast. He looked around the room. A nurse was reading Art's records. When she saw that Art was awake, she put down his records and said, "Well, did you have a good sleep?" "Where am I?" Art asked. "You're in the hospital," the nurse said. "You are lucky to be alive." "What happened?" Art said. Everything seemed mixed up. "You were in a bad crash," she said. "A very bad crash." [2]
Decoding Lesson 9	1. reared falling mound also waited Art first speaker Garner hardest league shouldn't almost always 2. worry voice exhibition stands jogged filed Hunt blinked shaking umpire James o'clock started stared struck 3 First Inning Art was going to pitch to some big league players before the game on Sunday. His coach had told him that he would be pitching to some of the best batters in baseball. The game was to start at one o'clock. Art was to begin pitching at noon. But at 12 o'clock there were not very many fans in the stands. Art walked to the pitcher's mound and picked up the ball. One of the players from the Tigers said, so "Just throw fast balls. The batter will hit them into the left stands. Some of the fans will get free baseballs." [1] Art looked up at the left stands. About one hundred kids were up there. Some of them had baseball mitts. Art said, "Should I throw as hard as I can?" "That's right," the player said. "Don't worry, the batter will hit the ball. You're pitching to James Hunt. He'll hit them, all right." 30 Art stared at the catcher's mitt. Then Art reared back and gave the ball the hardest heave he could give it. "Zip--pow." The catcher was on his seat. The player who was standing next to Art blinked and stared at Art. James Hunt looked at the catcher, and then he looked at Art. He blinked. [1] A fan yelled, "Did you see that? He shot that ball past James Hunt." Another fan said, "Hunt is trying to make the kid look good. He'll belt the next ball." But Hunt didn't have time to swing at the next ball. Before he began his swing, the catcher was on his seat again. The catcher jogged out to the pitcher's mound. He said, "Hey, kid, how do you do that? No pitcher has ever set me on my seat before. How do you do that?" "I just throw hard," Art said. And he did throw hard. He struck out James Hunt. [1] Art struck out other batters that day. Not many fans were in the park to see what Art had done, but every fan who was there was standing and clapping when Art left the pitcher's mound. Art walked over to his coach and sat down. His coach had tears in his eyes. "You are the best," his coach said. Then the coach for the Tigers walked up and sat down next to Art. He said, "Not many fans saw that. How would you like to pitch the first inning of the game? I think the fans should see what you can do. If you can strike out my Tigers the way you 31 did, I'll bet you can strike out any player on the Reds." "Okay," Art said, and

Title	Data
	he smiled. [2] Art was thinking, "Wow! I get to pitch to big league batters in a big league game." The fans filed into the ball park, and Art waited. Then a voice came over the loud speaker. It said, "Today a boy from your town will pitch for the Tigers in the first inning. This boy is one of the best pitchers we have seen. His name is Art Garner." The fans who had seen Art pitch before the game cheered and clapped. But the other fans didn't cheer. [1] One of the fans said, "We didn't come here to see kids play. We came to see the Reds and the Tigers." Art walked to the mound. Then he looked up at the stands. He had never seen so many fans before. Suddenly he became afraid. He began to think about all of the things that he shouldn't do. "Don't throw the ball too high," he told himself. The catcher tossed the ball to Art. And Art dropped it. "Boooooo," yelled some of the fans. "Get that bum out of here." Art's hands felt cold, and his legs were shaking. [2]
Decoding Lesson 8	1. started always whistle also groaned almost reared wound 2. league since pitcher couldn't two different what went want 3. batters crowded handshakes struck done tried tired there's stared star care Tigers you'll doesn't hadn't weren't winner ducked 4 Art Becomes a Star The best batter on the West team was at the plate. Art was thinking about what the catcher had told him. Art reared back. He let the ball fly. "Zip--pow." The catcher was on his seat again. "Strike one," the umpire called. "You can do it, Bob," the West fans yelled. Art got the ball again. He looked at the catcher's mitt. He reared back and let the ball fly. The ball started to go right at the batter. The batter ducked down. But almost before he could move , the ball curved and went right into the catcher's mitt. "Strike two," the umpire called. [1] 27 Again Art wound up and let the ball fly. Bob took a big swing at it, but the ball was in the catcher's mitt before Bob began to swing. "Strike three. You're out." "Oh, no," the West High School fans groaned. "Go, Art, go," the fans from Art's school yelled. And Art went. He struck out every other batter in the game. Art did not do well when he tried to bat, but his team was the winner. They beat West High School 3 to 1. Everybody from Art's school yelled and crowded around Art. They cheered. They patted him on the back. They gave him handshakes and smiles. [1] Art was so happy that he just sat down after all of the fans had left. He just sat and remembered the game. "Wow!" he said to himself. "I did it." After that first game, things were different in school. The kids smiled at Art. They went out of their way to talk to him. Art felt a lot better about school. In fact, school was a lot of fun for Art now. He waved to the girls. He wasn't afraid to talk to girls. He didn't look down when he talked to them. He had done that before, but now he was Art the Star, the big pitcher. [1] And Art started to talk like a star. He began to act like a big star. He began to make fun of some of the other kids. He began to show off in front of the girls. He began to talk a lot more. One day, he said to himself, "I want Patty to be my girl friend." So he walked up to her before class and said, "I'm not doing anything after school, so why don't we go for a walk?" "No, thanks, Art," she said. 28 Art didn't know what to say then. Since he had become a pitching star, nobody said, "No, thanks, Art." They always said, "Yes, Art." [2] Art looked at Patty. "If that's the way you want it," he said, and walked down the hall. He started to whistle, just to show her that he didn't care if she went with him. But he felt bad. He liked Patty. But there was something in the way she talked that told Art, "I don't like you, Art." Art was still thinking about Patty when somebody said, "Art. Art. The coach wants to see you right now." "What does he want?" Art said. The boy said, "I don't know, but it's something big." [1] Art went with the boy to see the coach. The coach said, "Art, there's going to be a big league baseball game in town. And before the game, they want some of the best high school pitchers to throw for the batters. I want you to throw for our school." "Will I play in the game?" Art said. "No," the coach said. "The Reds will be playing the Tigers. But before the game, you will pitch to some of the batters. Some of the other high schools are sending pitchers to do the same thing." "That will be fun," Art said. His coach said, "You'll be pitching to some of the best batters in baseball." [2]
Decoding Lesson 7	1. wouldn't reached coach breathed started streak called 2. umpire cheering catch silent fans who shouldn't mumbled 3. sting string Chuck stared zing guy plate want weren't doesn't isn't thrown clapping shaking strike ready taken state moment pitcher curve 4 Some Bad Pitches Art had just thrown a bad ball. And the West

Title	Data
	High fans were cheering and clapping. "That's the way to pitch," they yelled. The catcher tossed the ball back to Art, and Art dropped it. The West High fans cheered again. The fans from Art's school were silent. Art picked up the ball. He breathed in and out three times. Then he said to himself, "Don't throw the ball too high. Don't throw the ball too high." Art was not thinking well again. Art heaved the ball. It went like a streak. But it went about ten feet over the catcher's head. The catcher called time out and ran to the pitcher's mound. [1] 23 The fans from West High cheered. "Get another pitcher," they yelled. "This one has had it." The catcher said, "What's the matter, Art?" "I don't know," Art said. His hand was shaking. "I can't make the ball go where I want it to go." "Yes, you can, Art," the catcher said. "Just think about skipping stones. I'll hold out my mitt. You must throw that ball right into the mitt. Throw it just like you throw a stone. You can do it." "I'll try," Art said. The catcher jogged back, and Art rubbed the ball around in his hand. He looked at the catcher's mitt, and he said to himself, "I'll throw that ball right into the mitt. I'll do it." [1] Now Art was thinking the right way. He leaned back. His arm whipped back. The ball came from his hand like a shot. "Zip--pow." "Strike one," called the umpire. The fans from Art's school cheered. The fans from West High mumbled. They said, "Was that a lucky toss?" Art got ready for his next pitch. Everybody was silent. "Zip--pow." The catcher was down. "Strike two," the umpire called. The batter did not have a mean look now. He got set for the next pitch. He hadn't taken a swing at any of Art's pitches so far. Now he seemed set to take a swing at the next ball. [1] Art leaned back and--"Zip--pow." The catcher was down. And the batter began to swing after the ball had reached the catcher. 24 The fans from Art's school cheered and cheered. They jumped up and down. They hugged each other. They yelled, "Go to it, Art. Show them how to pitch." The fans from West were very silent. Then some of them began to cheer, "Come on, Chuck. Get a hit off that pitcher." Chuck was the next batter. He smiled as he walked up to the plate. The catcher jogged out to talk to Art. "This guy is good," the catcher said. "He is one of the best batters in the state. Don't give him anything he can hit." [2] So Art began to think to himself, "Don't give him anything he can hit. Don't give him a slow ball." Art was not thinking right again. He was thinking about what he shouldn't do. He should have been thinking about what he should do. He was telling himself, "Don't throw a slow ball." And what do you think Art did? He gave Chuck the biggest slow ball you have ever seen. And Chuck hit that ball right out of the park. The fans from West High jumped up and down. They hugged each other. They cheered and yelled. "A home run! A home run!" [1] The catcher jogged out to talk with Art again. The catcher said, "Art, that was a bad pitch. You can throw better than that. Just zing the ball in. Just think about skipping stones. You can do it." The next batter came up. He was as tall as Art. The fans clapped and cheered when he got near the plate. "You are the best, Bob," one of them yelled. 25 Art remembered that Bob was the best batter on the West team. For a moment, Art began to think about the things that he should not do. Then he remembered what the catcher had said. He stared at the catcher's mitt, and he said to himself, "I'll just zing the ball right into that mitt." [2]
Decoding Lesson 6	1. which leaned couch chest high right heaved cheered mound coach should beaten jeered 2. curve nobody throw clapped went want friend head catch state different pitches plate glared crowd mistake fans batter stuffed showed moment few whipped skinny 3 The School Team The coach wanted Art to show him everything he could do with a baseball. The catcher had stuffed a rag into his mitt so that Art's fast ball would not sting his hand so much. "Let's see your fast ball," the coach said. Art leaned back and--"Zip--pow." The catcher said, "Ow! That rag doesn't help very much." He tossed the ball back to Art. Art dropped the ball. He picked it up and looked at the coach. The coach said, "Now can you make the ball curve?" "What do you mean?" Art asked. "Make the ball bend to the left or bend to the right." "Oh, that," Art said. "Which way do you want me to make it bend?" 20 The coach stared at Art for a moment. Then he said, "Make it curve to the left." "Okay," Art said. [2] Art leaned back and to the side. He said to himself, "This is just like making a stone curve to the left." Art's arm whipped out to the side, and the ball went flying. It was going far to the right of the catcher. The catcher began to reach to the right. Then the ball curved and hit him in the chest. "Wow!" the

Title	Data
	coach said. "Who showed you how to do that?" Art said, "Nobody." Then he told the coach about skipping stones on the pond every day. [1] The coach had Art throw a lot of balls that day. The coach had him throw balls that curved to the left and balls that curved to the right. The coach had him throw balls that dipped down just before they reached the catcher. He had Art throw balls that jumped up just before they reached the catcher. The crowd on the side lines clapped after every ball Art heaved. And after every ten balls, the coach had a different catcher work with Art. After catching ten of his pitches, a catcher's hand was very sore. [1] Art worked out with the baseball team for three weeks. Then the team had its first game. The game was with a big school, West High School. West High was always a top team in the state. It had been the best team in the state three years before. Last year, it had been the third-best team in the state. Art's school had never beaten West High in a baseball game. 21 Art didn't sleep well before the game with West High. He kept thinking about the game. He wanted to do a good job. He hoped that he wouldn't throw a bad ball or make a mistake. About two hundred kids from Art's school went to the game. About four hundred kids from West High came to cheer for West. They cheered and cheered. But they jeered as Art's team came out to start the game. [2] Art didn't like to hear the West High fans jeer at his team. He said to himself, "Why are they yelling those things? They've never seen us play." But the fans from West High kept on jeering and jeering. West High was to bat first. So Art went to the pitcher's mound. The catcher tossed the ball to him, and Art dropped it. "Ha, ha," a fan yelled. "He can't even catch the ball. Get a rake! Can you rake that ball in? Ho, ho." The first batter was a big boy. He held the bat back and glared at Art. Art didn't like the way he glared, and Art tried not to look at the batter. [1] Art tried to think about pitching. He said to himself, "Don't throw the ball too high. Don't throw it too low. Don't throw it to the left of the plate. Don't throw it to the right of the plate." Art was not thinking well. He was telling himself what he should not do. He should have been telling himself what he should do. He should have been saying, "Throw that ball right over the plate--right over it." Art leaned back and gave the ball a heave. It went about nine feet over the catcher's mitt. [1]
Decoding Lesson 5	1. leaned catcher mound star heaved coach outfit whip formed could stained 2a. mope mop 2b. slim slime 2c. hate hat 2d. rode rod 3. few forward shaking pitcher asked thinner longer head just blowing moment silent we're tomorrow attention hollered crowd friend tossed pipular stuffed. 4 Art's Fast Ball Art didn't know what to do. He wanted to leave, but everybody was yelling, "Come on, Art, show us how to pitch." Some boys grabbed Art and started to lead him to the pitcher's mound. "Here he is, Coach," one of the boys hollered. "The star pitcher." 16 The coach walked up to Art. He said, "I don't know what this is all about, but we've got work to do out here. So throw the ball to the catcher. That will shut those guys up. Then get out of here." "Okay," Art said. The coach handed him the ball. [1] Art turned to the coach and said, "Do I just try to throw it at the catcher as hard as I can?" "That's right," the coach said. "Just throw it and get out of here." The ball felt a little too big in Art's hand. It didn't seem to fit as well as a skipping stone. He rubbed it a few times and got a good grip on it. Then he leaned back. "Show them how--if you can," the boys yelled. Art's long arm went back like a whip. Then it came forward like a whip. "Zip--pow." The catcher was on his seat. [1] Everybody was silent for a moment. Everything was still. Then somebody yelled, "Did you see that?" "No," somebody else yelled. "Did he throw the ball yet?" The catcher was blowing on his hand. He yelled, "Yes, I'll say he did!" Then everybody began to say things like, "Wow!" They didn't yell the way they had before Art had pitched. They just looked at Art and said, "Wow!" The coach said, "Let's see you do that again." The catcher tossed the ball to Art. Everybody fell silent as Art leaned back. His arm went back like a whip. Then he 17 heaved the ball. "Zip--pow." The catcher was on his seat again, shaking his hand and blowing into his mitt. [2] The coach said, "Wow! I don't think I've ever seen anybody throw a ball that hard." Art said, "I have to go now." He started to walk from the pitcher's mound. The coach said, "Art, I would like you to come out for baseball." Art stopped. "You mean you want me to be on the baseball team?" he said. "Yes," the coach said. "You have a real gift. You can become a fine pitcher." Art wanted to yell, "Hot dog!" But he didn't. He nodded to

Title	Data
	the coach and said, "Okay, I'll come out tomorrow after school." [1] When Art reached the crowd on the side lines, everybody stepped back and made a path for him. Bart said, "Good job, Art." Some of the other kids patted Art on the back. "Good pitching," they said. But Art didn't sleep well that night. He kept thinking of pitching. He kept thinking about the way everybody had said, "Good job. Good pitching." He liked the way they said that. He liked the idea of being a star pitcher. The next day after school, he dressed in a baseball outfit. [1] 18 Art said to one of the other boys on the team, "I've never worn an outfit like this before. It feels sort of funny." And it looked sort of funny. It seemed to make Art look taller than ever. It seemed to make his arms look longer and thinner. The coach met Art near the pitcher's mound. The coach said, "Today I want to see everything you can do with a ball. When I see what you can't do, I'll know what we have to work on." The catcher stuffed a big rag into his catcher's mitt so that Art's fast ball would not sting his hand so much. [2]
White Gates Afterwords	Dear Reader, Thank you for visiting Torin Sinclair's new hometown of Snow Park. Now that you know the secret of Leaping Water's people, I'd like to share my own encounter with wild Colorado river otters. A few summers ago, my family took a hike deep into the Rocky Mountains. We were fishing along a river when my little daughter slipped and fell into the icy water. We plucked her out quickly but she was already shivering. The rest of the family hiked upriver while I dried my daughter off and warmed her up. We were sitting quietly on a rock in the sunshine, wrapped in my jacket and cuddled close, when an otter popped up in the water and scrambled onto a rock across the stream. We sat, barely breathing, while the otter warmed up on its sunny rock. When the rest of the family returned, the otter disappeared. I made everyone sit and wait for what seemed like forever. I began to think we had imagined the otter. Then everyone gasped because we realized that an entire otter family was watching us from the far bank. The otter had gone home to collect its family so they could see these odd two-legged creatures. We stared at each other for a long time, and I don't know who was more fascinated, the otters or us. This magical river doesn't belong to my family. It belongs to the otters and other wild creatures, because in America we've decided to protect our most beautiful places and keep them free. These places, including our many national parks and forests, are treasures that we've agreed to keep for each other. Encounters like the one my family had with the otters can be moving reminders of why this is so important. —Bonnie Ramthun BONNIE RAMTHUN was born in Los Angeles, where her grandparents lived, because her hometown, Central City, Colorado, didn't have a hospital. Central City is an old gold-mining town in the mountains. It didn't have television or radio reception and back then there was no Internet at all. Bonnie and her brothers and sisters spent their summer days reading books. They also explored abandoned mining camps in the forest, an activity that was strictly forbidden and therefore irresistible. When Bonnie was nine, the family moved to Cheyenne, Wyoming, where she discovered that the mysterious "radio" her aunt had given her as a birthday gift suddenly started playing music. Bonnie started writing stories at the same time her radio started playing music. She has published three adult mystery novels. The White Gates is her first book for young people. Bonnie lives in Erie, Colorado, with her family and is hard at work on the next Torin Sinclair mystery. This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents either are the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental. Copyright © 2008 by Bonnie Ramthun All rights reserved. Published in the United States by Random House Children's Books, a division of Random House, Inc., New York. Random House and colophon are registered trademarks of Random House, Inc. www.randomhouse.com/kids Educators and librarians, for a variety of teaching tools, visit us at www.randomhouse.com/teachers Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data Ramthun, Bonnie. The White Gates / by Bonnie Ramthun.—1st ed. Summary: When his mother becomes the doctor in Snow Park, Colorado, twelve-year-old Tor learns of a curse placed on the town's doctors many years before by an eccentric Ute woman, but suspects that a modern-day villain is hiding behind that curse. [1. Blessing and cursing—Fiction. 2. Snowboarding—Fiction. 3. Physicians—Fiction. 4.

Title	Data
	Mothers and sons—Fiction. 5. Schools—Fiction. 6. Moving, Household—Fiction. 7. Ute Indians—Fiction. 8. Indians of North America—Colorado—Fiction. 9. Colorado—Fiction. 10. Mystery and detective stories.] I. Title. PZ7.R1485Whi 2008 [Fic]—dc22 2007012800 Random House Children's Books supports the First Amendment and celebrates the right to read. eISBN: 978-0-375-89232-5 v3.0
White Gates Chapter 17	Blessing THE CHAIRLIFTS STOOD silent now, their shadows making black squares over the brilliant emerald grass of the empty mountain. The snow was gone and so, too, were the crowds of skiers and snowboarders. The pine trees were almost black in the hot sun. Their trunks were cloaked in shadow and their branches were a perfect dark velvet green. The air was alive with butterflies and bees and motes of pollen and the excited chatter of birds and squirrels. Tor stopped for a moment and took out his water bottle. It felt strange to be wearing shorts and a T-shirt again, to feel the air lifting the hair from his forehead and brushing against his arms and bare legs. "Drake, stop," Raine called. Drake was walking ahead and hadn't seen Tor stop. Drake had given up his horrible winter sweaters, but his summer wardrobe included shorts in the most awful patterns Tor had ever seen. Today he was wearing neon orange and green plaid golf shorts. He turned, and then came back toward them, jumping like a goat down the slope. "Water break," Dr. Sinclair said. She wore shorts and a bucket-shaped hat that made her look hardly older than Raine. Her face was pink with exertion. "Is this where we head into the woods?" "Not quite," Raine said. "Just a bit further up." "Then let's rest for a minute," Dr. Sinclair said. She turned and sat down on the grass, sitting with her knees up and her elbows resting just like a snowboarder. Drake shrugged and sat down, obviously bursting with energy and wishing they would go on. Tor and Raine sat down next to Dr. Sinclair. The four of them contemplated the valley and the town of Snow Park, laid out like a tiny miniature toy town below them. "It's pretty from up here," Dr. Sinclair said, sipping from her bottle. She turned her face up to the sun and gave a sigh of happiness. Tor looked down toward home, planting his elbows on the warm springy grass. It seemed like he'd been here all his life. Raine tilted her head back like Dr. Sinclair and closed her eyes, smiling into the sun. Water beaded her face. Her hair was braided as always but she'd taken to wearing Ute beading in the loops that tied off the ends, and she'd sewn tiny beads in a pattern along the sides of her shorts. She didn't mind being a Ute anymore, Tor thought. "Come on, let's go already," Drake said. Tor got to his feet as Drake bounced impatiently in his plaid shorts. Raine flipped her braids over her shoulders, Dr. Sinclair pulled down her bucket hat, and they turned upslope and began to walk. The slope got steeper and more slippery as they walked steadily on. Finally they were at the top of the White Gates. Without snow they looked like stony scars on the mountain. Dr. Sinclair stood for a long moment looking down the avalanche chute, her eyes stricken, and then she turned to Tor with a shrug as if to say "I'm a mom, I can't help it," and followed Drake and Raine into the woods. "The judge was so eager to give us the land," Raine said as the trees closed around them. "I didn't think it would be so easy." "I think the judge was looking for an excuse to give the land back to you," Dr. Sinclair said gently. "Guilt, I suppose." "And he wasn't a snowboarder," Drake said. "Oh, Drake," Raine laughed, and threw a pinecone at him. "That's your pinecone," Tor said. He picked up another one and chucked it at Drake. "Here's another pinecone. Yours, all yours. We can throw them at Drake all day." "Oh, Tor, you don't get it, do you?" Raine said. She let her fingers trail down the branches of a tree. It gave under her touch and then sprang back up again after she passed. The pine smell was strong in the air. "I don't think of this land as mine, or yours, or anyone's. This mountain doesn't belong to anybody. It belongs to itself, and it always will." "What is this, a poem?" Drake asked. "I don't care if it sounds silly," Raine said, flipping her braids over her shoulder and glaring at Drake. "If we have to 'own' this land to protect it, then I'm happy to own it. But we know whose land this really is." "The river people," Tor said, and the breeze came through the pines and set the tops dancing. He laughed and swung his arms wide and spun in a circle. Drake clapped a hand to his head. "I'm going to retch," he said. "Say it," Raine said, and picked up a broken branch. She poked at Drake with it, and he jumped. "Say it, say the river people own this all." She chased him in a circle

Title	Data
	around Tor and his mother. Dr. Sinclair stood with her hands on her hips, shaking her head, and Drake finally threw up his hands as Raine stopped, panting, and made as if to throw the branch at him. "The river people, the river people!" he shouted, and Tor could hear the echo through the trunks of the pines. "This all belongs to the river people! There, you satisfied?" "Mostly," Raine said, throwing down the branch and panting. Drake was fast. "Just one more thing to do, and that's Dr. Sinclair's job." "Ah, yes, my task in this little jaunt," Dr. Sinclair said. "Anyone going to tell me what it is yet? Anyone going to fill me in on why I'm up here and who these mysterious river people are?" "Soon," Tor promised. "While we're young, Raine?" Raine waved her hand in a come-on gesture and they set off through the woods, angling deeper into the mountain. The hike was a lot longer on foot than it was gliding on a snowboard. They took another water break in a small clearing that was so dense with trees that Tor started to feel chilled in the shade. When they stepped into the sun again, he turned his face up to it and nearly killed himself stumbling over a log, which made Drake laugh heartily. Tor chuckled a pinecone and hit Drake in the seat of his neon plaid shorts. Drake yelped and started to chase Tor, but Dr. Sinclair made them stop. After they had continued walking for so long that Tor thought they'd gone the wrong way, he recognized the clearing in the trees ahead of them. "Quiet," Raine commanded, and they stopped. She stood for a moment, listening intently. Tor could hear the gurgle of water and the sigh of the breeze through the pine trees, and nothing else. Raine waved them on and they flitted like ghosts through the trees and came out on the small bluff overlooking the valley where the otters lived. The valley was alive with water. Multiple creeks chuckled and gurgled, joining a larger river that roared white as it disappeared out of the lower end of the valley. The sunlight was warm and full and the beaver ponds in the center of the valley glowed like blue jewels. Green grasses and spiky willow bushes lined the creeks and covered a marshy area. Tall aspen groves were still unfurling their pale green leaves. "This is beautiful," Dr. Sinclair whispered. They sat down at the edge of the bluff and Tor looked eagerly up and down the valley, seeking the sleek brown heads of the otters. There was nothing. Birds flew in and out of the willow trees and there was a low and sleepy hum of insects, but nothing else moved. Tor shifted a little and Raine laid a warm brown hand on his arm. "Peace," she said in a whisper so low he almost didn't hear her. Then he did, and he felt something inside him come completely unknotted. Whatever happened wasn't up to him. For the first time he really understood what Raine meant when she said she didn't own this land. He didn't own it either, and he didn't own the otters. They weren't going to appear just to entertain him, because they weren't his. Tor didn't know how long they sat there. The sun soaked into him and the sleepy hum filled him up. Dr. Sinclair was calm and still, moving only to breathe and to take a drink from her water bottle now and again. Maybe she, too, felt the timelessness of this place. Tor glanced at her and she was smiling gently. Drake tensed, and Tor saw the first of the brown heads break the water. He sighed and heard Drake and Raine sigh with him as an otter poured itself onto the land and stood looking around, eyes like black oil, whiskers twitching. A second otter tumbled out of the water and the two rubbed noses, then a third otter splashed to the shore. Dr. Sinclair didn't move. She sat still, her eyes on the otters. Tor could see the knowledge in her face, the comprehension. She knew what she was seeing. She drew a deep, slow breath. "The river people," she breathed out, and Tor, Drake, and Raine nodded as one. There was a long silence then, as they watched the otters play on the riverbank. They were a beautiful glossy brown in the summer sunlight. Their ears and tails were black and their noses were like a dog's, with a short snout and a black button nose. They seemed to relish rubbing noses, sliding their bodies over one another, and using their broad, powerful tails to flip water at each other like children having a water fight. Dr. Sinclair finally sat up straight, slowly, and put her hands out, palms up. "I promise," she said clearly, in a normal tone of voice. At her voice the otters looked up sharply and froze. "I promise to guard you. I promise to keep your secret. I make this promise to Leaping Water and her family. I make this promise to you." A moment later the otters were gone, sliding into the water with incredible speed and leaving not a single splash behind. Dr. Sinclair sat for a moment longer with her hands out, and then she dropped her hands and looked

Title	Data
	over at Drake and Raine, then at Tor, with a rueful smile. "I hope I didn't scare them away for good," she whispered. "No, I don't think you did," Raine said with shining eyes. "I don't think you did." "Was that right?" Dr. Sinclair whispered. "Was that what I should have said?" "That was exactly right," Drake whispered. Tor reached out and took Raine's hand. She reached out and took Drake's hand, and Tor felt his mother take his. They sat with hands clasped. Tor felt roots growing deep inside of him, roots growing into the warm earth. "There they are," Raine breathed, as the otter heads broke the surface of the stream. The second otter made a squeaking cry, glanced up at the four of them, and turned away, dismissing them. That was when the first of the baby otters appeared.
White Gates Chapter 16	The Envelope TOR'S MOM DIDN'T make a fuss over him, which was a relief. She stepped forward while Deputy Rollins was still being handcuffed and she took Tor by the arm. "Let's go, Tor," she said in a low voice. "You too, kids." Drake and Raine nodded and they followed her. A German shepherd dog lunged forward and sniffed Tor so enthusiastically he stumbled backward. The handler was smiling, and she reached down to pet the dog as it sniffed at Tor's legs. "Give her just a second," the handler said. She was a weathered woman with deep wrinkles around her bloodshot eyes. Tor realized she'd been up all night searching for him, too. "We hardly ever find them alive, and avalanche dogs get awfully depressed. Saber here needs to know she's found her boy. Yes, you found him, good girl, good girl!" The dog wagged her brushy tail back and forth joyfully as Tor reached down to let her sniff his hand, remembering what the pine tree had looked like as the falling avalanche crushed it. No, he didn't suppose that Saber often found avalanche victims alive. "I'm getting him out of here," Dr. Sinclair said to Sheriff Hartman, who was trying to lean past her and catch Tor by the arm. The CBI agent, Mr. Graham, was busy with the deputy and the crowd was closing in: Gloria and her Ski Patrol friends, dressed in red and looking both exhausted and happy; Ms. Adams; Mr. Ewald, the math teacher. Tor felt Drake and Raine behind him, pushing him toward Dr. Sinclair, and then they were walking through the lodge. Someone tried to take his snowboard from his arm and he jerked back fiercely, protectively. Then he realized it was Mr. Douglas, Raine's dad, who made a soothing gesture with his hands. Tor let the snowboard go. The street was too bright outside the lodge, and there were too many people crowding around. Mr. Douglas shoved ahead of them and opened a door, and Tor found himself walking up a flight of stairs, half-carried by strong arms. Things seemed too light and then too dark, but it didn't seem important to ask any more questions. Someone pushed a hot drink into his hands. "Drink it," his mother said gently, and Tor sipped at it. It tasted strongly of honey but underneath was some kind of bitterness that didn't taste good at all. "That's awful," he said, but Dr. Sinclair pushed it back into his hands. "Drink some more, Tor," she commanded gently, and he gulped it grudgingly down. There were hands all over him, it seemed—pulling off his boots, taking off his helmet, tugging at his snowboarding jacket and pants. "No signs of frostbite," he heard someone say, and realized it was Mr. Douglas. Something in the tea was bringing everything back into focus again. Tor was sitting on the couch in the Douglasses' apartment, and his mother had him undressed to his thermal underwear. "Hey!" he said, as he realized Grandma Douglas was watching him. She was sitting in a chair that Raine usually curled up in, looking no bigger than her granddaughter. Her black eyes crinkled as she smiled at him. "He's not hurt a bit," she said to Dr. Sinclair. "I think you're right," Dr. Sinclair said. She was feeling Tor's bare toes, examining them one by one with gentle hands. Mr. Douglas was also in the room, Tor saw. There was no one else there. "Where's—" he began. "In the kitchen, getting some food," Mr. Douglas said. He was looking at Tor's fingers with the same intensity Dr. Sinclair showed, examining each finger as though he was looking for something. "They're exhausted. They've been up all night waiting for word about you. We wouldn't let them on the mountain until this morning, which didn't sit well with either one of them." "We practically had to sit on them to keep them from going up with the search party," Dr. Sinclair said. "It was a long night for us down here, Tor." "I'm sorry," he said. "Oh, don't say that," Dr. Sinclair said, and touched his toes very gently with her warm, strong hands. "No sorrys, no tears, not on this day. No frostbite here, not a sign. I'll keep an eye on your feet

Title	Data
	and hands for a few days to be sure, but there's no white or green patches, and you don't seem to be in any pain." "The mine wasn't that cold, and I had my gear on," Tor explained as his mother took his head in her hands and started feeling through his hair. "How did you get cut?" Dr. Sinclair asked, looking at Tor's forehead. He couldn't remember for a moment, then he did. "The tree," he said. "When the avalanche crushed it, it shot splinters into the tunnel entrance. I fell back and hit my head—with my helmet on, Mom!" he said, annoyed, as Dr. Sinclair felt his head again. "I'll get some fresh clothes for you, Tor," Mr. Douglas said. "Dr. Sinclair, the sheriff is going to want to take a statement from Tor." "The CBI man will, too," Dr. Sinclair said, her lips thinned. "He can just take Tor's statement right here. I won't let him take a sick boy to the police station." "I'm not sick!" Tor protested. "I think that's quite clear." Mr. Douglas grinned and left the room. Dr. Sinclair pressed an icy stethoscope to Tor's chest. He gasped and then resigned himself as she listened to his lungs, felt his belly, and looked in his ears. "Mom," he said finally. She sat back on her knees and looked up at him. She was smiling. "I know, overkill. I just have to know you're okay. I thought you were dead, Tor. All night." "I'm sorry," he said again, and his voice thickened so he cleared his throat. "Don't be. It wasn't your fault," Dr. Sinclair said. "And I'm not going to wrap you up like a baby and keep you from that mountain and from your snowboard. I would never do that." "I know," Tor said. He had never thought she would. "I just would—I would have missed you, that's all," Dr. Sinclair said, and she sat down on the couch next to him and held him, hard, and she did cry a little, after all. Mr. Douglas came into the room with an old pair of sweatpants and a soft jersey for Tor, and a box of tissues for Dr. Sinclair. He smiled and winked at her when he handed her the box. Tor pulled on the sweatpants and sat back down. Dr. Sinclair was blowing her nose when Drake and Raine pushed into the room, followed by Mrs. Douglas and her young son. Behind them came the round form of Sheriff Hartman. Tor was pulling on his jersey and froze, seeing the sheriff. "Son, I need to take a statement," the sheriff said. He raised his hands in a peace gesture toward Tor, who sat back down on the couch. His sad hound eyes looked tired. Drake and Raine sat down firmly on either side of Tor. Dr. Sinclair stood up. "You're not moving him," she told the sheriff. He sighed and looked around the room. "The CBI agent is going to be here any minute. Let me know what happened so I know what's been going on with my deputy. Can you tell me that?" "I...okay," Tor said. "Start at the beginning," Sheriff Hartman said. Tor started with the fridge full of blood. He had come up with a story already—he was looking for his mom, who wasn't at the office, and he knew that she and Mayor Malone had agreed to go out for coffee, so he went to the mayor's office looking for them. "I was just wandering around looking for them," he said, as innocently as he could manage, "and I saw the fridge from the clinic in the back room. I knew it belonged in the clinic so I looked in it. I saw there were blood bags in there, so I left and talked to Drake and Raine about it." He looked at Drake, then at Raine. They nodded, as though they'd rehearsed the whole story and there was no nighttime break-in of the mayor's office. "We spoke to Ms. Adams at the school," Tor said. "Why Ms. Adams?" the sheriff asked. He had taken a seat and was writing in his notebook. "Because she was friendly to me," Tor said. "Everyone else treated me like an outsider. Like I was cursed or something." He looked innocently at the sheriff and was pleased to see the big man shift his feet and look faintly ashamed. "We couldn't trust the mayor because we—I—found the fridge in his office. And I was afraid to go to you." "Deputy Rollins was my deputy," the sheriff said. "Notice the past tense. There's nothing worse, in my opinion, than a lawmaker who won't uphold the law. Where are you going to turn if the lawman is bad? You young folks decided you couldn't turn to me, so you talked to the choir teacher at the school. For heaven's sake, the choir teacher." "Yes, sir," Tor said slowly. If he'd gone to the sheriff, he'd never have found Leaping Water, either, or the—"My jacket!" "Right here, Tor," Raine said, picking it up from beside the couch. "What is it?" "Later," Tor said, taking it in his hands and feeling the slight crackle of paper. "Later." "Where did you go after Ms. Adams promised to bring in the CBI?" "And here he is now," Mrs. Douglas said as the doorbell rang. "We're getting quite a crowd here. Hold on a moment." Mrs. Douglas brought back the CBI agent, Ms. Adams, and Mayor Malone. In the meantime Raine pushed a turkey sandwich into

Title	Data
	Tor's hands, and he wolfed two enormous bites. He lifted the sandwich toward Ms. Adams in greeting as she entered and she smiled back at him. He didn't smile at Mayor Malone. "Here's the choir teacher," Sheriff Hartman said, standing up and hitching at his heavy belt. He reached forward to shake hands with the mayor, the CBI agent, and finally Ms. Adams. "The most trusted woman in town, I hear." Ms. Adams lifted her chin until she looked as regal as a tiny queen. "That's what I hear, too," she said. "I trust you'll forgive me for not coming to you?" "Having the CBI called in over my head isn't my favorite moment as a lawman, frankly," said the sheriff. He nodded coolly at the CBI agent. "I had three young people put their trust in me," Ms. Adams said, a red blush climbing her neck, her chin held even higher. "Their lives were at risk. I did what I felt I had to do." "There's no blame attached to this," the CBI agent said, his face as calm and still as a carved block of granite. "Ms. Adams did the right thing, and so have you, sir. We have Rollins in custody and the evidence safely in hand, and no one's been hurt. You're not hurt, are you, son?" "Nope," Tor said. "I'm Mr. Graham, Tor. I'm very glad to see you're okay. I'm going to need a statement—" "You can take a formal statement after he's had a meal and some rest," Dr. Sinclair said firmly. Mr. Graham looked at Tor, who took another huge bite of his turkey sandwich. "How about coffee and sweet rolls?" Grandma Douglas chirped. "I want to hear the rest of Tor's story." Mr. Graham sighed and took a seat in a chair. He looked exhausted. "We found evidence of foul play in the death of the Slader boy," he said. "We'd just opened the investigation when Ms. Adams's husband, Joe, called me. I spent the night up here looking for you. I thought you were dead, and you show up alive and hand me the killer." "You're welcome," Tor said through his mouthful of sandwich. He wasn't sure what he was supposed to say. "I'll tell you what," Mr. Graham said. Everyone leaned forward. "I'll take his statement in a few hours, after he's had some rest." "But what about us?" Grandma Douglas wailed. "Well, he can talk while he's resting," the CBI man murmured, looking out the window and scratching his chin. "That is, if he wants to." "I want to," Tor said. He noticed Mr. Graham fiddling with his shirt pocket after he scratched his chin, and he thought perhaps Mr. Graham had a recording device in that pocket. He didn't mind. He wasn't trying to keep a lie straight; he was simply going to tell the truth. He talked himself hoarse, while Mrs. Douglas and Grandma served coffee and a sweet sticky pastry, while Sheriff Hartman wrote busily, and Mr. Graham finished his pastry and then rolled a toothpick slowly from one corner of his mouth to the other. The mayor sat quietly with his hands folded over his big belly. Tor tried to explain how he'd been so happy to make it through the trees that he wasn't aware he was in the White Gates, and how he'd figured out too late that Jeff and Max were screaming at him to stop. "They said 'stop'?" Sheriff Hartman asked, raising his head from his notes. "They tried to stop me," Tor said. "They really did. I don't think they meant to chase me into the White Gates, and I know they didn't mean to set off the avalanche." "My boy," Mayor Malone said huskily. He cleared his throat, but said nothing else. "We know they were trying to save you, Tor," Dr. Sinclair said. "They told everyone where you were so we could search for you." "They might tell you about the blood doping, too," Tor said. "If you ask them, I mean. I don't think they knew that's why Brian died. Deputy Rollins, he—" "Just plain Rollins, if you please," Sheriff Hartman said. "Rollins, I think he talked them into blood doping," Tor said. "I don't think they knew Brian died from the blood doping. They thought his death was my mom's fault, and Rollins, he wanted them to believe that, too. They were mean because they were scared, that's what I think." "That doesn't excuse their behavior," Ms. Adams said sternly. "They knew what they were doing. They knew it was wrong." "Your son never told you about the blood doping, sir?" the sheriff asked. "Not a word," the mayor said heavily. "They'll be quite a help, I think, now that they know the truth," Mr. Graham said through his toothpick. "You went through this...gate?" "Over a cliff," Tor said with satisfaction. "But the snow was so deep I didn't get hurt. I was stuck in the snow for a bit until I worked my way loose. Then I heard the avalanche siren and felt the rumbling." Dr. Sinclair gripped the edge of the desk as Tor explained how he'd scooted back to the cliff, trying to shelter in the rocks, and had seen a dark space that might hold him. When he explained about the avalanche crushing the tree to bits, everyone leaned forward intently, hanging on his every word. It was very gratifying. "I found Raine's

Title	Data
	flashlight in my pocket," Tor said. "From...from walking home the other night." He'd almost said when they'd broken into the mayor's office. "My flashlight!" Raine gasped, and gave a little sigh. "I'd forgotten you still had it." "Lucky I did," Tor said. He could feel a surf of exhaustion rolling toward him, cresting like an ocean wave coming into shore. Not all the tea or sandwiches in the world were going to keep him awake much longer, but he had to keep talking. The best part was coming up. "I walked for what seemed like forever through the tunnels. Then I found a lantern, and matches," he said, and took a deep breath. "They were sitting right next to your great-great-great-grandma, Raine." His words fell into a silence as deep as a well, as deep as the silence in the tunnel. Even Mr. Graham had stopped rolling his toothpick, and his mother and Ms. Adams looked like statues on either side of the desk. "Leaping Water?" Raine whispered. "Yeah," Tor said, and reached inside his jacket. "She gave me this, Raine. For your family. She was waiting for me." "Waiting for you," Sheriff Hartman said in a blank sort of way. He wasn't writing anything down; his pencil was held in the air like he'd forgotten he was holding it. "Yeah, for me. The healer's son. She wanted me to break the curse, of course," Tor said impatiently. He held out the envelope to Raine. "This belongs to your family. We have to protect her people now. That's our job now." "It's the deed to the mountain," Raine said in a tiny voice. She handed the envelope to her father, who looked at it as though he'd forgotten how to read. He held it out to his wife, who passed it to Grandma Douglas. Grandma Douglas held it to her chest and bowed her ancient head. "That's the original deed?" Mayor Malone asked. He sounded wheezy, like he'd been hit in the stomach. "What is the significance of this?" Mr. Graham asked. He looked both puzzled and irritated. "What is this?" "This is the deed to the Borsh Mountain land," Mr. Douglas said, taking the envelope from Grandma Douglas and holding it carefully in both hands. "This is the proof that my family needs to keep the development from going forward on our mountain." "Or you can sell the mountain and keep the money for your family," Mayor Malone said desperately. "There's that. There's a lot of money—" "No," Tor, Drake, and Raine said as one. Everyone turned to look at them. "We have to protect our people," Raine said proudly, her chin up. "That is what Leaping Water did. That's why she gave the deed to Tor. That is our duty now." "Tor found a skeleton in a tunnel," Mayor Malone said. "That's what he found. Talking about protecting some mythical people, that's crazy talk. You'll want to think this over, Mr. Douglas. That's a lot of money we're talking about there." "Thank you, sir," Mr. Douglas said gently, and tucked the envelope in his shirt. "I'll certainly consider it." "What does this have to do with Brian Slader and blood doping?" asked Mr. Graham impatiently. "Nothing, and everything," Tor said. "The curse on the town is what Deputy—er, Mr.—Rollins used to keep the blood doping a secret, even after Brian died. That's why the snowboarders chased me out of bounds. That's why Jeff and Max tried to knock me down and instead I ended up in the White Gates. They believed Brian died because of the curse. It all happened because of the curse." "What curse?" asked Mr. Graham, and Tor sat back for a bit while the room erupted in noise and explanation. The warmth of Drake against one side of him and Raine on the other was so comforting that Tor actually began to doze off. "Tor, don't fall asleep," Ms. Adams said, and Tor snapped awake to see that everyone was looking at him again. "I'm awake," he insisted, though all the angles of the room seemed to be bent in strange ways. He blinked. "What?" "How did you get out?" Sheriff Hartman said. "The light, in the morning," Tor said. "The light and the breeze down the passageway. I found the crack in the wall and kicked my way through. Then I saw the gray wall and the ladder." He laughed, because it seemed so funny now, and rolled his head on the couch to look first at Raine, then at Drake. His head was much too heavy to lift now. "I thought maybe I was dead, the room was so white and strange and there was the silver ladder right up to heaven, but it turned out to be the ladder on the chairlift pylon. There was a hatch at the top, and I came out to see that I was back on the mountain. The rest, you know," he said tiredly, and closed his eyes again. "The construction crew must have blocked up the mine tunnel when they dug the chairlift pylon," Mayor Malone said. "That was the way out," Dr. Sinclair said. "He found the way out." "Kicked my way out, really," Tor mumbled. "Well done, son," Mr. Douglas said, and Tor could have sworn he was close to tears. "Yes, well done," Ms. Adams said, and he was

Title	Data
	sure she was crying. "Oh, it wasn't really me," Tor said at the very edge of sleep. "Not me. Drake and Raine and me. It was us." "Yeah," Raine whispered. Drake made an embarrassed shrugging movement that jostled Tor and reminded him of something. He turned his head to Drake and it seemed to take forever as the room slowly rotated and Drake came into view. "I never saw anything like that jump you made when you made Deputy Rollins crash," Tor mumbled. "You think you could teach me that move?" "Yes," Drake said, "I will." That was the last thing Tor remembered. He dreamed of otters, and Leaping Water, and bells that rang like music in the darkness.
White Gates Chapter 15	The Race TOR HEARD MUSIC. He was making it. His snowboard cut through fresh powder with a sound like tearing paper, and as he switched back and forth to keep control, he heard the music of his board and he heard the music in his head. He knew he couldn't outrace Coach Rollins. He was just a kid and he hadn't been snowboarding very long. But there was music in the way his board cut through the snow. There was music in the clear blue day and the sunlight. Tor felt no fear at all. Instead, he felt a goofy kind of happiness filling him. The sun was shining and the powder was perfect, his friends were coming, and his snowboard was singing the "Gloria" in Ms. Adams's song. The baritone was an easy part. Just a bunch of O's, like a snowboard gliding down a hill. He would be at the bottom in a few minutes and he shouldn't have wished it, but he found himself wishing the run were going to take longer. Then Tor heard a panting like a wolf and the tearing-paper sound of a snowboarder coming fast. Rollins had caught up to him. Tor crouched down, trying to get more speed. His heart tried to climb up into his throat. His board was singing and he knew he was going to win. He had no idea how, but he knew he was going to win this race. "Tor, go left!" Raine shouted from behind him, and without hesitation Tor threw his board to the left, toe-side into the mountain. He watched as the snow slid past his nose, and when he reached out a glove to steady himself, an arc of snow sprang up in a head-high spray. Rollins was a blue blur, coming fast. Tor crouched and headed straight for the trees. There was another path on the other side of the trees, a narrow glade called Moose Hollow, and he knew Rollins was forcing him in there because no one could see them from the resort. They'd be hidden until the bottom of the run, which emptied out directly in front of the lodge. But Tor knew he had no choice. If he stopped now, Rollins would catch him and take his papers, his proof, and then no one would ever believe him. He had to beat Rollins to the lodge. He rocketed between the trees and burst into the Hollow. Trees dotted the slope and powder sparkled on every branch. There were no tracks in the fresh snow, and it glittered at Tor like a million diamonds. He had to grin as his board floated into the powder and he curved around the first pine tree. The snow was awesome! "Tor, right!" Raine screamed from somewhere behind him, and Tor instantly threw his board to the right, missing a tree by a millimeter. A cascade of snow fell from the tree, as though he'd startled it. Then he saw Drake. Tor had never watched Drake ride. He'd never seen anyone ride like that before. Drake cut in front of Rollins, who threw his board into a turn that sent him toward the trees. Drake cut in front of him again, his board sending up a curve of snow like a surfer's wave. Rollins dodged again and Drake moved even before the bigger man had finished his turn, blocking him again. Tor saw Drake's teeth show in a grin that looked as sunny and innocent as a little kid's, and then Drake threw his board into the air right at Rollins, and Rollins turned desperately to avoid the impact. Rollins went into the trees and Drake hit the branches of a pine tree. White snow cascaded down as Drake twisted in midair, flipped over, and came down on the slope. He was perfectly in control. Tor had never seen anything so incredible. He knew he was grinning and laughing at the same time because his teeth were freezing. He turned his board downslope and kept going. Raine was on the other side now, and the three of them raced together down the mountain. Tor heard the song inside his head, singing about mountains echoing in reply. He didn't realize he was singing out loud until Raine joined in. "Angels we have," she sang, and turned on her board as Tor and Drake turned, too, the three of them together. "Heard on high," she continued in her soprano voice. She was short of breath and panting, but she sounded beautiful. "Sweetly singing," Tor and Drake sang together, as they turned

Title	Data
	again on the slope. "O'er the plains," they sang together, and it wasn't nearly as good as everyone sounded in Ms. Adams's class, but Tor didn't care. It sounded great to him. "And the mountains in reply." They turned again, throwing sprays of white powder into the air in three perfect arcs. "Echoing their joyous strain." Tor couldn't help laughing as he heard their voices bounce off the slopes of the valley and, indeed, echo in reply. They all took a deep breath and came down the final slope, bursting out of the trees and racing toward a waiting crowd, and they were singing. "Glo-o-o." Tor lost the last section of O's because he started laughing again. "Ria. In excelsis deo." Tor picked up the last section with Drake and Raine and they came to a stop, spraying snow into the air from the edges of their snowboards. Tor thought that definitely showed some attitude. He felt just fine about it. Tor saw his mother, and there was Ms. Adams at the very front of the crowd. She stood with hands clasped and her mouth trembling, and she was crying but suddenly she was clapping her mittened hands together, banging them against each other. She was applauding. Tor reached down to unclip his board. There were more people coming toward them, running, and some were running the other direction and shouting the news to people in the lodge. Tor was still unclipping when he sensed more than heard the sound behind him. Drake and Raine, who'd unclipped faster than he had, were ready. They turned and held their snowboards like weapons, facing back upslope. Tor stepped out of his board and turned around to see Rollins coming downslope fast, his nose and chin covered with blood and his eyes blazing out of a furious white face. "You stop!" Raine screamed, and jabbed her board toward Rollins. "You stop right now!" "What's going on here?" someone asked behind Tor, and he turned around to see Mayor Malone standing next to his mother and Ms. Adams. The mayor was dressed in an enormous brown parka. His face was flushed pink with the cold and his mustache was frosted with ice. "Left, Tor," Drake said casually, and Tor jumped to his left. A split second later, Rollins came through the space where Tor had just been. Tor stood next to Drake and watched as Rollins tried to stop, overcorrected, and smashed to the ground at the feet of Mayor Malone. The mayor was splattered with snow. It was all very satisfying. "If he's armed, we're toast," Drake said. "You think he's that crazy?" Tor asked. "Yeah, he's that crazy," Raine said in a perfectly conversational tone of voice. She moved to Tor's other shoulder and the three of them stood together. They waited, still panting, their snowboards upright and held at their sides. "What's going on here?" Mayor Malone asked again, staring angrily down at Rollins. Rollins rolled over and groaned, then fumbled at the straps of his board. "I have proof he was blood doping the snowboarding team," Tor said quickly, before the deputy could unstrap and get up. "That's why he's trying to hurt me. I've got the proof right here." Tor patted his chest, and looked at Drake and then Raine and saw their stunned faces. They didn't know, he realized. They didn't know about the blood bag receipt, or Leaping Water in the mine, or any of it. They were protecting him and they didn't even know why. He felt a hitch in his stomach. Tor turned back to his mother, who looked shocked, then, with dawning comprehension, very angry. "What are you talking about?" said Mayor Malone. "Blood doping?" Dr. Sinclair said, shoving her way ahead of Mayor Malone. "Did you say blood doping?" "Yes," Tor said. "I found a blood bag receipt and it has Deputy Rollins's fingerprints on it." Tor suddenly became aware of a strange humming noise. It was the chairlift, rolling empty chairs up the mountain and circling them back down. There wasn't another sound. The crowd that surrounded them had gone absolutely silent. Plumes of white breath rose in the air from a hundred mouths, but no one said a word. "That's why Brian Slader died," Tor said loudly, and his voice, maddeningly, trembled. He forced it lower so it wouldn't shake. "Deputy Rollins took too much of Brian's blood. We found blood bags. Blood bags with the snowboarding team's names on them. He takes blood from them and puts it back in before competitions so they can win. But he took too much blood from Brian." "This story is crazy," Rollins said. He was on his feet and he had wiped the blood off his chin. He looked calm and grown-up, and Tor suddenly felt very small and very young. "This boy ran away from home. He caused the whole town to search for him for nothing, and now he shows up with some wild story." "I didn't run away," Tor said. "I got chased into one of the White Gates. I went off the cliff. I was in the avalanche." "No one could survive in the

Title	Data
	White Gates," sneered Deputy Rollins. "No one could survive an avalanche in the Gates. You're lying. You're a liar!" "I found a mine shaft," Tor said. He glanced at Drake and Raine again and started grinning. He couldn't help it. That goofy happiness was filling him again. "I found one of the Borsh tunnels and I hid in that. It took me all night to find my way out. That's the truth." There was a shifting murmur in the crowd, which seemed to be swelling by the second. Tor caught a glimpse of Gloria and she was smiling at him but her eyes were bloodshot and red. Could she have been searching for him, too? He knew that she had, as sure as the sky was blue. She'd been searching all night for him, while he was lost in the dark. She hadn't given up, and neither had Drake, or Raine, or his mother. They'd been looking for him. The whole town had been looking for him. "That's a damned lie," Rollins said. "He comes to this town, his mother comes to this town, and people die. That's the truth. He sets off an avalanche that nearly kills two town kids—" "They set it off!" shouted Tor. "And now he claims he found the Borsh mine. You believe this? Anyone believe this pile of lies?" "I have proof," Tor said, and the words silenced the swelling murmurs of the crowd of townspeople. "Proof?" sneered Rollins. "What—" But he stopped, because Tor had drawn something from his pocket. "These are matches from Borsh's General Store," he said. The hidden envelope stayed in his jacket, a warm secret like a heated coal. He held the box up in the air. "I found them in the mine." It was as good as a magic trick, that tiny box. Tor could see the stunned expression on Rollins's face. "My son is no liar," Dr. Sinclair shouted over the excited chatter that burst out. "I don't need to see proof to know that. And I'm a doctor. Brian Slader died from blood loss, not pulmonary edema. He died because he didn't have enough blood in his system. Rollins, have you been taking blood from your snowboarding team? Have you been blood doping?" "I certainly have not!" Rollins shouted, and Tor heard the panicked lie in his voice as clearly as the ringing of a bell. The crowd murmured and shifted again and then fell silent. Tor saw people turning to look at a group wearing blue jackets. The snowboarding team stood, looking at the ground, saying nothing. Tor looked at his friends. Drake was still holding his snowboard at the ready, shoulder to shoulder with Tor. Raine was at his other shoulder, her eyes glittering like black oil in the sunlight. "We found a refrigerator from the clinic," Tor continued. "It was full of blood bags marked with team names. Then I found this." He reached into his jacket pocket and pulled out the receipt. It was wrapped in the glove. The glove looked small and pitiful and flabby in the clear morning air. There was an uncomfortable silence. Tor swallowed hard. "I'll take that," someone said, and Tor saw a man step out from behind Ms. Adams. He was wearing a heavy navy blue parka with a furry hood, and as he pulled the hood back Tor saw a tight-fitting blue cap on the man's head. The cap held a patch that shone with gold. It was a badge. "It's about time," Drake murmured, and blew out a breath that sent a cloud of white vapor into the sky. "Who are you?" Tor said, although his heart was already beating with hope. "Ford Graham, Colorado Bureau of Investigation," the man said, and the words were the Excalibur sword that Tor wished he could have pulled from his jacket instead of the flabby little glove. Behind the CBI agent was Ms. Adams, who was nodding at Tor with a smile that made her look like a very satisfied little wood elf. "I can take you to the blood, too," Tor said. "If they haven't moved it." "We'll take a look," the man said. "I'm glad to see you're okay, son. We were worried about you. Can I have that evidence, please?" Tor handed it over, and as he did he saw Rollins and the expression on the deputy's face wasn't fearful at all. Tor felt his heart sink like a stone. "You aren't getting anything off that paper!" Rollins hissed, in a voice so full of hatred that Tor felt Raine quiver next to him. "I wore gloves! You're not getting anything off that paper!" Tor felt like he'd been punched in the stomach. All the work he'd done! The risk he'd taken to keep the receipt safe, all that he'd been through. He'd snowboarded off a cliff, he'd nearly died, and the paper had turned out to be worthless. There would be no fingerprints, no evidence for the jury, and no arrest. He'd failed. Then he saw Deputy Rollins's expression. His face was shocked and he was no longer looking triumphant. He was instead looking at the CBI officer, who was staring back at him with an expression of profound satisfaction. "Well, that was a stupid thing to say," Graham said, smiling. "And in front of witnesses, too. Sir, it doesn't matter if this receipt has fingerprints on it or not. With this, I can

Title	Data
	find out who paid for those blood bags. Care to let me know whose name I'm going to find at the end of that trail?" Rollins looked down and wiped at his bleeding nose. He said nothing. Mayor Malone stepped forward. Tor watched him. He'd thought the mayor was the killer the whole time, and he'd been wrong. The mayor was a creep, but he wasn't a murderer, and the look on the mayor's face said it all. His face was dead white. He looked sickened, as though he was about to throw up. "You took blood from my son?" he said, his voice cracking. "You took my Jeff's blood?" The mayor lunged toward Rollins but someone abruptly blocked his way. Sheriff Hartman had on a big hat and a dark brown parka with a shield pinned to the front, and his face looked more than ever like a mournful basset hound's. "Move back, now, move back, Stanford," Sheriff Hartman said. His voice was as deep and sad as his face. "Some detectives we turned out to be," Drake murmured to Tor, and he had to pretend to cough in order to keep from laughing out loud as the sheriff tried to keep the mayor from Deputy Rollins. "Hold him," the CBI agent said to the sheriff. Then he took silver handcuffs from his pocket and said the magical words to Deputy Rollins that made Drake and Raine and Tor smile like they'd each gotten a brand-new snowboard on Christmas morning. "You have the right to remain silent...."
White Gates Chapter 14	Stairway TOR LEAPED TO his feet, his heart kicking in his chest like an animal trying to tear its way out of a cage. He snatched up the lamp and it was so hot he nearly lost his grip and dropped it. He clutched the handle in his hands and bit back a whimper. How long had he been asleep? Grandma Leaping Water still sat, as she always would, peaceful and quiet in her nest of blankets. Just looking at her steadied Tor. There had to be more than one entrance and exit to the mine tunnels. He'd just have to find another way. The flame guttered in the lamp as if it was mocking him, and he willed it to keep burning. It guttered again, the flame almost torn from the wick in the breeze coming down the passageway. Tor blinked, and realized what he was seeing. The wick was streaming back because there was a breeze. Somewhere there was fresh air blowing into the mine. He turned without taking his eyes from the wick and tried to see where the breeze was coming from. It was coming down the same tunnel he'd gone down hours before, the one that ended in a blank wall. He must have missed something, some side tunnel perhaps. He set the lamp down and picked up his snowboard, and then he turned to Leaping Water. "Is this the right way?" The amused, young-sounding voice that he'd heard in his head hours ago didn't come back. Maybe he'd imagined the whole conversation. Tor tapped his finger at his chest and felt the crackle of parchment. He hadn't imagined the envelope. He picked up the lantern by the wire handle and walked down the tunnel, lamp held high, snowboard gripped in his other hand. There were no side tunnels. The lamp took him to the same dirt wall. The lamplight glowed across it and showed Tor nothing but brown stuff that smelled bitter and dank. He stared at the lamp, willing it to show him where the breeze was coming from, but it guttered a final time, the flame was torn from the wick, and the light was drowned by darkness. Tor stood for what seemed like a long time, stupidly willing the lamp to relight, but it hung from his hand silently. It was now nothing but a cooling lump of metal. He shook it and heard no sloshing sound. He set the lamp carefully on the ground. He put down his snowboard, resting it against one wall, and it was only then as he made sure it wasn't going to fall over that he realized that he could see his snowboard. And he had seen the lamp when he put it down. Tor looked around wildly. There was light coming from somewhere. It was coming from the dirt wall in front of him. There was a crack, thin as a silver wire. Tor got to his hands and knees, and a cold breeze blew on his face as he tried to see what was beyond the crack. He couldn't see anything, but he could tell the crack led to something and there was light in there. It had to be a way out. He sat down on the tunnel floor and kicked at the crack with all his might. The impact jarred him to the top of his aching head and he groaned. He kicked again, this time lying on his back and scooting close to the wall so he could kick with all his strength. After the third kick, when he knew he couldn't do it anymore, he felt something give way. There was a sound like a branch snapping, and his boot was suddenly calf-deep in the wall. Tor pulled his foot away carefully and got up to look through the hole he'd made. There was

Title	Data
	nothing but dazzling whiteness. Tor couldn't see trees or snow, and somehow it didn't look like open air. Whatever it was, there was light in there. He sat down again and kicked at the edge of the hole. This time an entire section broke free and Tor scrambled backward as dirt and white rock came thudding down. Choking gray dust filled the air, and Tor coughed and moved backward down the tunnel, waiting for the air to clear. When it did, Tor nearly whooped out loud with joy. There was a boy-sized opening in the wall. Light and fresh cold air poured through the hole. Tor carefully scrambled through and pulled his snowboard after him. He stood up and looked around. He had no idea where he was. He was standing in a small room. There was a wall in front of him, a wall that looked like it was made of grayish-white clouds. There was a silver ladder bolted to the wall. Tor contemplated this for a while. Finally he stepped forward carefully and looked to make sure the ladder didn't lead downward, too. Then he looked up. He didn't know what he was going to see, and he was more than a little afraid. Far above him there was a square hatch. Pure light outlined the hatch and flooded down into the room where he stood. Tor put a hand out and touched the gray wall. It felt like concrete, cold and smooth, and it curved slightly as though he was standing in front of some huge column buried in the earth. The other walls in this strange room were also painted gray. Tor looked back at the hole he'd crawled through and saw chunks of plaster on the ground. His breath smoked in the cold air and drifted upward toward the hatch. The ladder was solid and just as real as the walls. Finally he tucked his snowboard under his arm and put his hands on the ladder. The hatch had to be the way out. He started to climb. Halfway up, the ladder began to thrum like a plucked guitar string. Tor almost lost his grip. He clung to the ladder, panting, the thrumming sound making his very bones vibrate. He forced himself to keep going, though he was shaking. He shoved away the tiny, miserable thought that he'd had enough already, that somebody should help him, that he was only a kid and he'd gone through too much to go on. Thinking like that was halfway to giving up, and Torin Sinclair didn't give up. "Torin Sinclair always gets back up," Tor muttered to himself, and he reached the hatch at last. The hatch looked very ordinary. It was made of a shiny metal, and there was a latch and a handle so a person underneath could lift it. Tor rested his snowboard on his knees, took a deep breath, and tried to open it. It resisted, and he braced himself and shoved, hard. The hatch opened. He climbed out into blazing sunshine and deep white snow. Tor sat on the edge of the hatch, his eyes smarting in the light, and realized he had been climbing a ladder on the side of a huge gray tower, a column of concrete. He followed the tower up to the sky and saw cables, and then he saw the chairlifts go sailing smoothly by and the tower thrummed as the chairs thumped over its support bars. He'd found his way to a chairlift pylon. He'd been at the bottom of the pylon, buried deep in the earth, and he'd climbed up the mechanic's access ladder. The hatch was sheltered by an overhang and surrounded by padding, but some snow still blew in and that was what he'd had to move when he'd opened the hatch. He was back on Snow Mountain. Tor felt something inside him come bubbling out. It was laughter, and he let it go free. He laughed and laughed, holding his snowboard in his hands, his feet still dangling in the hatch, and the blue sky overhead was the most beautiful sight he'd ever seen. He was alive. And he was sitting right next to a chairlift pylon on the groomed slope of the Snow Park resort. Tor put his goggles on. He closed the hatch and climbed the protective orange padding that surrounded the pylon. He'd never looked closely at a pylon before. He'd always just avoided them like everyone else did. Now Tor could see that the padding surrounded the pylon and the access hatch. Once he was up and over the padding, Tor could see the slope and the town below. He sat in the snow for a moment and just looked at it. Snow Park had never looked so pretty. The roofs were covered in snow and the streets sparkled in the sun. Cars drove down Main Street, heading toward the resort parking lot. The resort must have just opened, because only a few coats were milling down by the chairlift and the parking lots were just starting to fill up. The lodge looked busy, with lots of people wearing red Ski Patrol jackets standing outside. To his left and just downslope was a small warming hut and snack bar. Tor had never been in there. It was used mostly by small kids and their parents, who needed to warm up and let the little kids take breaks. They serve hot chocolate, Tor thought, and his stomach growled savagely

Title	Data
	at him. A single hot chocolate, he thought, and then he remembered what he carried. If he was caught before he found his mom, or Drake and Raine, he'd lose the evidence he'd nearly died to save. No matter how cold and hungry he was, his job wasn't done. Tor sat and worked his boots into his snowboard bindings, clipped in, and hopped to his feet. He glided downslope. The cold air bit at his exposed nose and cheeks but it felt great. He had to keep that paper safe and get it into safe hands. Tor stopped to settle his goggles around his eyes. He looked up at the chairlift, wishing with all his heart that he would see Drake and Raine up there. And there they were. Tor nearly fell down. Raine was on the chairlift, wearing her yellow-green coat. Drake was right next to her, his mittens clutching the lift bar and his head thrust forward from his shoulders like he was trying to get the chairlift to hurry up. Tor filled his eyes with the sight of them, his friends. They were coming to look for him. "Hey!" he shouted. "Raine! Drake! Hey!" They turned their heads toward him slowly, as though they were wondering if they were dreaming. Tor shouted again and waved both arms, laughing. "It's me! It's Tor!" he shouted. "I've got the proof! I'm alive and I've got the proof!" Three chairs ahead of Drake and Raine, someone turned abruptly and looked at Tor. There was Deputy Rollins, now dressed as Coach Rollins in snowboarding pants and an electric blue jacket. He stared at Tor, his face white and grim, and the look on Rollins's face told him everything he needed to know. Tor had been wrong the whole time. The vampire wasn't Mayor Malone, after all. The vampire was Rollins. Tor looked back at Drake and Raine, and they were looking at Rollins, too. It was so obvious now. Rollins had been the one who was blood doping the team. He had everything to lose if his secret was found out. He'd lose his coaching position, his job, and his reputation. He was Coach Rollins of the Snow Park snowboarding team, the team that won championships, and Tor knew his secret. Tor knew that Rollins had taken too much blood from Brian Slader and had killed him. If Rollins caught Tor, he would never make it off the mountain alive. And Rollins was about to get off the chairlift. "Tor, go, go!" Raine screamed from the chairlift. Drake was already pulling his goggles down, and both of them were shoving their free feet into their snowboards, getting ready to exit the chairlift with both feet strapped in, a move that Gloria told Tor she'd rip his head off like a daisy if he ever tried. Tor didn't wait to see if they made it off the lift. He turned and pointed his board straight downhill and rode for his life.
White Gates Chapter 13	Avalanche Chute THE FALL TOOK only seconds, but it seemed like a lot longer. Tor windmilled his arms, trying to keep upright. His heart climbed right up into his throat and stayed there, beating frantically, and he kept breathing in but couldn't seem to breathe out. The trees flashed by; first the tops, then the increasing width of the branches, then the trunks. He couldn't see anything beneath him, because he didn't look. His board disappeared into snow and Tor followed. Then the snow gripped his body and he stopped with a jar that shook him from his head to his toes. Tor saw sparks and stars in front of his eyes and a darkness like curtains flapping in front of him. He breathed out, and then breathed in again with a wheeze, and the stars and curtains started to fade. Tor panted and looked around, his board buried and his body upright. He was stuck like a toothpick into the snow all the way up to his armpits. Trees crowded close on each side, covered in white and showing only flashes of green needles and brown trunks. Tor looked over his head and saw a sheer cliff face above him that was so high he nearly started seeing stars again. He'd stopped before he hit the rocks that were probably inches underneath his board. All the heavy snow that they'd had lately had piled up so deeply it made his landing a big soft pillow. Tor started working himself up out of the snow, hearing himself making a chuckling sound under his panting breath. He didn't like the sound; he sounded like a little kid getting ready to cry. His snowboard came free and Tor laid back, arms spread-eagled like he was going to make a snow angel, feeling sweaty and hot. His heart still pounded hard but it was back down in his chest now, and his breathing was better. That odd noise he'd been making seemed to be done with for now, too. Suddenly there was a piercing siren in the distance. Tor sat bolt upright. He'd never heard anything like it before. It was high and shrieking and said Danger! as clearly as someone screaming out loud. He looked wildly left and right, scooping some stray snow from the front of his

Title	Data
	goggles, but he didn't see anything. Then he realized he was feeling something. The snow was trembling under his legs and backside. Earthquake! Tor gathered his legs close to himself, wondering what to do and where to go. The trembling increased, and Tor realized he was hearing a sound over the shrieking of the siren from the town. The sound was distant and rumbling, coming closer by the second, a sound like an ocean wave crashing toward shore. This wasn't an earthquake. This was an avalanche. The siren was to warn the town that an avalanche was coming. And Tor realized with a sick feeling that he was sitting at the bottom of one of the avalanche chutes. The White Gates were avalanche chutes. "Stop, stop, please!" Jeff and Max had yelled, their screams echoing off the snow-filled avalanche chute. Tor saw in his mind the echoing sound of their yells, bouncing off the walls of heavy snow that had been building for weeks. Their shouts had started the avalanche. The snow was coming right at him. Tor started scooting backward toward the cliff face, his snowboard digging into the snow. Perhaps if he got right up at the edge of the cliff, the avalanche would fall over like a waterfall and he would be safe behind it. It wasn't much of a chance, but it was all he had. He'd seen avalanche footage on a snowboarding video that Drake had brought over to show him. Drake's dad and his cameraman had boarded safely away from an avalanche as the other camera had caught the gigantic cliff of snow breaking away and sliding downhill, gathering up pine trees like they were miniature toys and smashing down toward the valley floor below. The rumbling was getting louder, and the shaking stronger. In just a few seconds a wave of snow was going to break over the cliff and bury everything underneath it in snow. Tor bumped up against the rocks at the cliff edge and felt a stinging as a sharp rock smashed into his back. He looked wildly around, trying to find a deeper spot where he could wedge himself, and saw an opening between two rocks. He shoved his way between the rocks and lifted his snowboard straight up and down so he could unclip the bindings and kick it away. If he got rid of his snowboard, he might be able to squeeze between the rocks and hide. The entire world was shaking around him, worse than any earthquake he'd ever been in, worse than any earthquake on any movie he'd ever seen. His teeth were chattering and his fingers wouldn't take hold of the bindings, and he jammed his back harder against the cliff wall. Suddenly two enormous boulders of snow exploded over the cliff edge and came rocketing toward the earth below. The earth behind him moved and Tor moved with it, shoving himself backward as though he was trying to dig into the cliff. Then, just as he realized what he was feeling wasn't rock but wood, the wood gave a cracking sound and fell away. Tor fell backward into blackness, his snowboard following him, and landed hard on his back inside an opening in the cliff. Stars and sparks shot across his vision again and this time he heaved for breath, without doing much good. The breath had been completely knocked out of him, and for a moment or two all he could do was try to get his lungs to work again. He was still trying to get some air when the rest of the avalanche came roaring over the cliff. Avalanche snow wasn't powdery and smooth. It was hard and full of trees and rocks. The remnant of a pine tree smashed down right in front of Tor. It was destroyed, split into shredded bark and broken branches. Abruptly it was swept away by more snow. Tor scrambled backward, digging his board into the floor, as more and more snow shook the earth and thundered down, right where Tor had been standing before he fell. Another pine tree fell into the opening in front of him. Suddenly a massive downpour of snow crushed it. Tor could hear the cracking of the trunk and the splintering of the branches, as though the snow was eating the pine tree alive. It would have been him, if he'd still been standing against the cliff. A juicy smell burst from the tree as it gave up all its sap, and Tor threw his arms over his face as splinters shot into the cave entrance and pelted him. His helmeted head hit the floor with a smack and everything went away for a while. A long time later Tor sat up. The tree was gone and there was nothing in the entrance but white that was rapidly turning to a dark gray. He felt a stinging on his forehead and reached up. A splinter was stuck straight into his head and Tor thought crazily for a second that he'd been impaled. The splinter fell out of his forehead as he touched it and he realized it had just scratched him. There was a sticky wetness on his face but there wasn't much of it. He gave a shaky laugh and then stopped, because he didn't like the sound. His fingers finally stopped trembling, and he managed to

Title	Data
	unclip his snowboard. He stood up carefully and stepped toward the gray oval that was the cave entrance. He touched the snow with his gloved fingers. It felt as hard as iron. It was more ice than snow. Tor remembered the enormous pine tree that had been crushed into pine-tree jelly right in front of him, and felt a shiver that he stopped at once. If he was going to get out of here, he couldn't start panicking now. He leaned his board against the cave wall and realized he was terribly thirsty. Scooping snow from his board, he held it in his mouth until it melted. There were granola bars in his pockets, he remembered. And also Raine's flashlight. With a burst of relief he slapped his pockets and felt the reassuring roundness of her light. In a moment he had it out of his pocket and turned it on. The darkness lit up around him, and Tor stood staring in wonder. He wasn't standing in a cave. He was standing in a tunnel, with sturdy timbers bracing the walls and a hard-packed floor underneath him. "This is a mine," Tor said to himself, and heard his voice echo behind him. He turned and looked down the tunnel. The light disappeared into inky blackness. This could only be one thing. This was the Borsh mine. Raine's great-great-great-grandfather's mine. Tor remembered how no one went on Borsh land, because there were too many dangerous mine shafts. Mr. Ewald had fallen into one, and a hiker had lost his life. The flashlight trembled in Tor's hands as he looked down the blackness of the mine tunnel. He turned back to the oval entrance and wondered if anyone knew he was there. Had Jeff and Max told anyone? Would they call rescuers and try to dig him out? Or were they high-fiving each other right now, knowing their problem was solved? Tor felt his jaw muscles clench. He touched his jacket and felt the outline of the blood bag receipt, safe in its latex glove. There was no way he was going to let them win. He picked up his snowboard and turned his flashlight so that it shone deeper into the tunnel. The floor looked level and clean, almost as though it had been swept, and the timbers that supported the walls seemed thick and well braced. "Okay, Mr. Borsh, I'm counting on you," Tor said, and heard his voice go ahead of him into the darkness. He followed. He found the first intersection a long time later. He had no idea how deep into Borsh Mountain he'd gone, or even if he was going straight into it. The air was as still as a held breath. He contemplated the inky blackness that waited in four directions. He sat down for a bit and ate a granola bar and scooped some more snow from his snowboard. He'd started forward again when he remembered that he had to mark his trail. He tore the empty granola bar wrapper in half and set it in the middle of the tunnel that led back. He found a small rock to hold it down. The tunnel was so clean and neat he had trouble finding even a small rock, and the thought of round Mr. Borsh sweeping his tunnel with a broom was so funny Tor laughed again. This laugh sounded stronger, more sure. He decided to take the right turn, just because it sounded good. He walked down the tunnel and noticed his flashlight beam was getting a bit yellow. He tried to keep the panic down, but it nibbled at him like rats with sharp teeth. He could die in here, he knew that. There was no point in dwelling on it. After the third intersection of passageways, he started tearing his granola bar wrapper into small shreds so he'd have enough pieces of paper. There was nothing in the mine but clean-swept floors, timbers, and dirt. Tor was running out of granola bar wrapper when he realized there was something ahead of him. The yellowing beam of the flashlight didn't quite reach whatever it was, and Tor stopped, uneasy. There was something on the floor of the mine ahead of him and it felt familiar. Strangely familiar. He stepped closer, gripping his snowboard hard in one mitten and holding the flashlight hard in the other. The thing on the floor of the mine didn't move as he approached it. Then he was in front of it, and his flashlight fell out of his suddenly boneless fingers and thumped dully on the thick softness of a woven blanket. Tor crouched down on one knee, and then he was sitting on the floor, his snowboard on his lap. After a long time, he found his voice. "Hello, Grandma," he whispered. Leaping Water was perfectly preserved in the dry tunnel. She sat cross-legged, her beautiful deerskin dress faded to a vanilla yellow in the fading glow of the flashlight, her head bent down as though in thought. Tor couldn't see her face. Her white hair was braided the same way Raine liked to do, lying long and thick down her shoulders. She was seated on a soft woven blanket, and she had on deerskin moccasins that were covered with beads that glinted deep red, purple, and green in the glimmering light. Tor didn't feel frightened at all. This was no corpse from a zombie movie. Leaping

Title	Data
	Water looked as peaceful and serene as though she'd just gone to sleep a little while ago. Next to her was a small scrap of paper that held within it the remains of what looked like bread and perhaps some kind of fruit. All that was left were dry withered twists. On the other side was a lantern. Tor stared at this for several minutes before his brain figured out what he was looking at. He leaned forward. Could it still have fuel in it? After all these years? "Grandma, can I use this?" he asked politely. She didn't object, so Tor reached forward and picked up the lantern. It sloshed, sounding full, and Tor sighed happily as he saw a package of matches tucked in the wire that held the lantern glass. He took it out and read out loud: "Borsh's General Store." The matchbook held one match. Tor was careful with the lantern, taking the globe off and removing the small brass cap that covered the wick. The sharp smell of kerosene filled the tunnel. Tor struck the match and when the wick caught fire, he felt a burst of happiness. He sat back and turned off the flashlight and then adjusted the wick so the lantern gave off a steady light. Then he took out a granola bar. It didn't seem odd to offer Grandma a bar, though she had no interest in it. "We found the otters," Tor told her. He took a bite of his granola bar. "Your people. I'm so glad you didn't sell the land. That you kept it for the river people. We watched them. Did you know they like to play in the snow?" Of course, Grandma replied in amusement. I watched them for years. "Yeah, I know. I bet they're even better in the summertime, to watch I mean. I bet they play all day." All day, Grandma said. They love to play. "So I'm the doctor's son," Tor said finally, scooping a last bit of snow from his snowboard and putting it in his mouth. "I guess you knew that. Is that why I'm here?" That is why you're here, Grandson, Grandma said. Yes. That is why you're here. "Well, okay," Tor said. "What do you want me to do?" But Grandma was silent on this. She looked down in her lap, as she had done for the past fifty years or so, and finally Tor realized she was trying to tell him something. Her hands rested on something in her lap. The something was an envelope, and Tor knew what it was. "That's the deed, isn't it?" he asked. Yes, it is, Grandma said. You may take it. "Okay," Tor said. He felt nervous about touching Leaping Water, but only because he didn't want to disturb her. The envelope was thick and yellow, and as Tor pulled gently at the corner he touched her and she jingled musically. There were bells sewn into her hair braids and her deerskin dress. "I bet you were great to know," Tor said. He tasted salt and realized his cheeks were wet. "Your great-granddaughter is terrific, too. Your whole family, actually." You missed a few greats in there, I think, Grandma said. But yes, I know. Tor looked inside the envelope and saw the thick parchment. Mining Deed of Trust, he read, and felt a light bloom inside him that was stronger than the kerosene lamp. "Thanks," he said. There didn't seem to be anything else to say. The envelope went into his jacket pocket, where it rested next to the blood bag receipt. Tor remembered a high-wire act he'd once seen, where the artist carried a long pole. On one side was a tea tray complete with a steaming teapot and on the other was a small poodle dog dressed like a clown. The burden was just too ridiculous to be believed. Tor touched his jacket and remembered how the artist crossed the wire with small, careful steps. "One step at a time," Tor muttered to himself, and he set off down the passageway in the direction he'd been going when he'd met Grandma. This had to be the way out. The envelope crackled in his pocket, and the lantern was warm and lit up the whole passageway. But the tunnel ended in a blank wall. Tor stood for a long time, wondering what was going on. He had the deed, Grandma Leaping Water had shown him where to go—where was the door? He put down his snowboard and pushed and prodded at the wall. Maybe there was a secret door there? A secret exit? The wall was rough and seemed to be made up of hardened dirt, not stone. Tor pushed harder at the dirt, but it acted just like dirt and nothing happened. Tor finally turned around and sat down, thumping his back against the wall. He'd been so sure! Exhaustion suddenly rose up in him. His eyes were sore, his head hurt, his throat was raw, and he was thirsty again. He'd ridden the White Gates, he'd fallen off a cliff, he'd escaped an avalanche and found Leaping Water and her deed, and after all of that he was going to die here. For nothing. He put his head down on his knees and clutched his helmeted head with both hands, and he put every ounce of will into not crying. Eventually Tor got up and walked back down the passageway. There didn't seem to be anything else to do. After a few minutes Grandma appeared in

Title	Data
	the lantern light, waiting, eternally serene. Tor sat down next to her and leaned against the wall. He set his board down and turned his head to look at her. "Well, unless you have any other ideas," he said, "I'm fresh out." Grandma remained silent. Tor let his head rest against the wall. It was cold in there, but not freezing. His snowboarding gear kept him comfortable. He let his eyes close, just for a moment, to try to collect his thoughts. When he opened them, he couldn't figure out where he was. His head ached, his body hurt everywhere, and his mouth was dry and sticky. Everything was blurry. He moved, groaned, and finally sat up. He'd been resting on the edge of Grandma Leaping Water's blanket. For a moment Tor remembered with perfect clarity that he'd been dreaming of the otters. Grandma had been an otter, so full of life and fun that she splashed like liquid sunlight as she romped in and out of the river, and he'd been running after her on his four clever feet, his tail bumping and his whiskers twitching, making a yipping sound of happiness before he plunged into the cool stream water.... Then the dream was gone like smoke because the lantern was guttering. He'd been asleep and he'd left the lantern on. He had no more matches and the flashlight was just about dead. The lantern, his only light, was about to go out and leave him forever in the dark.
Decoding Lesson 4	1. Raising blush starting couldn't baseball night greenhouse team tallest corner sailed coach 2a. not note 2b. rip ripe 2c. at ate 2d. hide hid 3. Guy attention popular head friend pitcher motorcycle catcher idea 4. starting laughing doesn't smiled Jackson trying isn't throw players lesson crowd wave Mark couldn't football ready shook walk sorry 5. The Baseball Lot Art was having a bad time in school. The kids didn't talk with him, and he didn't know what to say to them. After school, Art would go to the pond to skip stones. And as he skipped them, he said the things he would like to say to Patty. "Patty," he said to himself one day, "I want you to be my girl friend." He skipped a stone and looked at it as it sailed almost to the other side of the pond. Then he said, "No, I will never say anything like that to Patty. I would just blush, and I wouldn't be able to say anything." [1] After school one day, Art saw Patty standing on the corner near school. He walked up to her. "Hi, Art," she said. "Hi," he said. He breathed in deeply and said, "Can I walk with you?" She smiled and said, "I'm waiting for somebody, Art. Sorry." "That's okay," Art said, and he began to walk down the street. He looked back from time to time. When he was about a block away, he saw Mark Jackson walk up to Patty and begin to walk with her. The next day, one of the kids told him that Mark Jackson was Patty's boy friend. Mark was one of the most popular boys in school and also one of the smartest. [1] Later that day, Art went to the pond and skipped stones. The pond was starting to freeze, and the air was cold. "I wish I were a big football player," Art said to himself. He tossed a stone as far as he could. It went all the way to the other side of the pond. Art smiled. He had never skipped a stone that far before. Then winter came. The winter seemed very long to Art. But at last spring came and the trees started to bud. Now it seemed that the kids paid even less attention to Art. [1] 13 "Maybe everybody has other things to think about now," Art said to himself. And they did. Some of them had motorcycles. Some had bikes. Some had boats. Some had girl friends. And some went out for baseball. The baseball team worked out on a lot near the school. Art passed the lot every day. Sometimes he looked at the team before he went to the pond to skip stones or to the greenhouse to help his dad with the roses. One day, Art stopped on his way home. He was standing next to a boy named Bart. "Hi, Art," Bart said. "Take a look at this pitcher they've got. He can make that ball buzz." So Art took a look. [2] The pitcher seemed to wave his arm around. Then he tossed the ball, and the catcher grabbed it. "Did you see that?" Bart said. "That ball went like a shot." Art smiled. "Was he trying to make the ball go fast?" Art asked. Bart stared at Art. "What do you mean, trying? He made that ball go so fast, it went like a shot." Art shook his head. "That wasn't very fast at all," he said. Bart folded his arms. "Can you throw it any faster?" "Well, yes, I can. I can throw it a lot faster." "That's a good one," Bart said, and started to laugh. [1] Then Bart called, "Hey, guys, we've got somebody who can throw the ball a lot faster than your pitcher. This guy can do it. He told me so." 14 A lot of other kids began to laugh. Then one of them yelled, "Hey, Coach! Why don't you let Art here show you how to throw the ball?" Art looked at Bart.

Title	Data
	"Well, I can throw it faster than that," Art said. "Okay, he's ready," Bart yelled. "He just told me so." Everybody was laughing. Art didn't know what to say. He turned around and started to leave. But everybody was yelling, "Come on, Art. The coach wants you to give his boys a lesson. Come on." [2]
Decoding Lesson 3	Lesson 3 1. each fold coach would 2. raised thirteen greenhouse smaller blushed started always breed swing 3a. slope slop 3b. made mad 3c. cop cope 3d. pin pine 4. studied botany skim basket checks pond clod tried 5. fellow blade hang fifteen lonely dribble smile block grow school stuck nothing skipping shy stared stayed flowers two grown Patty along show laugh burn different front shoot walked 8 6. Lonely Art Art was a farm boy. He talked like a farm boy. He walked like a farm boy. And when he was thirteen years old, he began to grow. When he was fifteen years old, he was taller than any other kid. His arms seemed too long. He looked like a long blade of grass. After school, he didn't hang out with the other kids in his class. He went home to work on the farm. The other kids in his class said, "Art's a loner. He never hangs out with us." They didn't know that Art was shy. [1] A teacher in the school told Art that he should go out for basketball. And Art did. But he hadn't played basketball before. And he wasn't any good. He couldn't shoot the ball. He couldn't block shots. He couldn't dribble the ball. The coach said, "Art, this game is too hard for you. Why don't you try out for another sport?" But Art didn't try another sport. After school, he went down to the pond near his farm house. He skipped stones on the pond. He said to himself, "I just wish there were a stone-skipping team. I'd be the champ of that team." [1] Art could skip stones across the water like nothing you have ever seen. He could make the stones turn to the left or turn to the right. He could make them skip way up into the air. Or he could make them skim along the water. And if he took a big swing, he could make a stone skip almost to the other side of the pond. 9 But there was no stone-skipping team, and Art didn't have much fun in school that fall. He felt like a big clod. He felt that the other kids had a lot of fun, but he didn't fit into their plans. Art would smile and try to talk with them. But he didn't know what to talk about, and they didn't seem to want to talk. [2] Then, in the winter, things were different. Patty came to Art's school. She was in two of Art's classes. One class was botany. Art tried to think of botany when he sat in that class, but Patty sat right in front of him. And every time he looked at Patty, he stopped thinking about botany and started to think about Patty. One of the things they studied in botany was flowers. Art raised roses in his dad's greenhouse. So Art took some roses to school one day. He was going to show them to the class. One of them was a breed that Art's dad had grown. [1] Some of the boys saw Art going to class with the roses. "What are you going to do with those flowers, Art? Give them to Patty?" In class, Art showed the roses to the teacher and the other kids. The teacher asked Art to tell about growing roses. So Art did. But he didn't give a very good talk. He kept looking at Patty. When the class was over, Patty came up to him. She said, "That was a very good talk, Art." She had never said much to Art before, and Art felt funny talking to her. All of the other kids were looking at him. [2] 10 Patty said, "Those are very pretty roses. What are you going to do with them?" "I don't know," Art said. "May I have one of them?" she asked. Art blushed. "Yes, you can, Patty," he said. His cheeks felt hot. He gave her the biggest, reddest rose. "Thanks a lot, Art," she said. "See you later." She walked from the room. Then Tim came up. He stuck his finger in his mouth and said, "Say there, you big fellow. Can I have one of those roses, too? How about it, Big Boy?" He winked at Art. [1]
Decoding Lesson 2	1. call high waiting fort salt sore night forest 2. about breathed third bald card fainting feared smallest 3A. robe rob 3B. rat rate 3C. ride rid 3D. hoop hope 4. laugh burn straight die wouldn't choke closed knocks ready shown bet taken deeply tired our afraid turn stinks 5. The Little Bug Wins the Meet There was a contest in the garden. Five stink bugs were trying to see who had the best stinker. All of the bugs but one had shown off their best stink. Now that bug began telling the others how good she was at stinking. She talked and talked. The other bugs began to leave. Now only the biggest bug was left. 5 The little bug with spots said, "If you wish, I will give you a very small stink. My smallest stink will choke you up for three hours. Would you like me to do that? Or would you like me to give the

Title	Data
	stink of stinks?" [1] "I'm getting tired of waiting," the biggest bug said. "No stink can be as good as you say your stink is." The little bug said, "Then you're set for my stink? Breathe in deeply and hold in the air, for here it comes." "No, wait," the biggest bug said. "Maybe I'd better go to the other side of the garden. I'll stand there, and I'll be able to get a better whiff of your stink." The biggest bug was afraid. She feared that the smell would do her in. So she went to the other side of the garden. [1] The little bug asked, "Have you taken a big gulp of air?" "Yes," the biggest bug said. "Are your eyes closed?" "Why should I close my eyes?" the biggest bug asked. "My stink will burn your eyes so badly that you will not see straight for three days. My stink is so powerful that even bats get sore eyes when I turn on my stinker." The biggest bug closed her eyes and breathed in deeply. Then she said, "I'm all set." The little bug asked, "Are you grabbing onto something? Nobody can stand up when my stink reaches them. First it hits them so hard that they fall down. Then it knocks the air from them. And when it has done that, my stink chokes them up. But most bugs don't die from the smell. They are just sick for weeks." [2] 6 The biggest bug said, "Wait. I'm not ready. I think I'll back up a little more." "Tell me when you're ready," the little bug said. "I'll count to ten, and then I'll turn on my stinker." "All right," the biggest bug said, and that bug began to run. She ran so fast that the grass bent down as she went past. She ran up the hill on the other side of the garden. She didn't turn back. She didn't call to the bug. She just ran. The little bug said, "That big stink bug can really run." Then the little bug began to laugh. That bug laughed so loud that a bird came to see who was making all the loud sounds. [2] "Why are you laughing so hard?" the bird asked. Soon the bug stopped laughing. The bug said, "I'm laughing because I got rid of all those stink bugs." "I'm glad of that," the bird said. "Where there are stink bugs, there is a lot of stink. I hate stink bugs." "Me, too," said the little bug. "Why should you hate stink bugs? You're one of them." The little bug said, "I'm not one of them. I would never make a stink." "Why wouldn't you make a stink?" the bird asked. The little bug went, "Ho, ho." Then she said, "Because I am a lady bug." [2]
Decoding Lesson 1	1. first proud garden blushed beat 2. birds hard cloud tears leaving our 3A. grip gripe 3B. tim time 3C. site sit 3D. cone con 4. close choked powerful right stared taking these whiff stinker low flying risks you're skunks noses why talked done nobody said striped taken turn 5. Five Stink Bugs Have a Contest There were five stink bugs that lived in a garden. Stink bugs are proud if they can make a big stink. The biggest stink bug in the garden was very proud. She said, "This is how to make a stink." And she made a big stink that you could smell on the other side of the garden. The fattest stink bug said, "If you think that her stink is so hot, look at what I can do." The fattest bug gave out with a smell that filled the air for three blocks. Page 2 The other bugs held their noses. They said, "That was as good a stink as we have smelled for some time." [1] The next stink bug had a striped back. He said, "If a bug has stripes on its back, it has the best stinker. Here I go." And there he went. A stink came from him and fell like a cloud on the other bugs. They rubbed their eyes. They said, "If the air does not clear soon, we will pass out." A bird was flying over the garden. She looked at the stink bugs in the garden and said, "What are you bugs doing? Don't you think that you'd better stop stinking? Remember there are others who have to smell your stink, too." [1] "Stop talking," the striped stink bug said to the bird. "Can't you see that we are seeing who has the best stinker?" The bird said, "Yes, I can see that. And I can smell that, too." The bird left. The next stink bug said, "I'll bet that I can beat the rest of you in making a stink." So that bug began to make a stink. It was so bad that the other bugs choked. The biggest bug said, "Ugh! That was some stink!" A rabbit at the other end of the garden called out, "So far as I can tell, you all smell the same. And that's bad. I have tears in my eyes. I cannot see. So I ask you, please, stop stinking." [2] "Stop talking," the biggest bug said to the rabbit. "We can't take time from our stink meet to talk to you. We are in the middle of something big." Page 3 The last stink bug was the smallest of all. She had spots on her back. She said, "Now that the rest of you are done, let me tell you about the stink that I'll make. Don't come too close when I begin stinking, or you will get so bent out of shape that you will never be the same. Nobody can stand the smell that I make." [1] The smallest stink bug kept talking. She said, "In the last garden I was at, I took the first

Title	Data
	prize for stinking. I have taken more prizes for stinking than all of the stink bugs in this land. When I let go, my stink will lay you low." The fattest stink bug said, "You're doing a lot of talking, but you're not doing much stinking. If you came to stink, start stinking and stop talking." The smallest bug stared at the fattest bug. She said, "All right, I'll give out with my stink, but soon you will know why I told you about it before I let it go. You will see why I took time to tell you what it would do. When you are choking in the grass, you'll wish that I had made you leave the garden." [2] The striped bug said, "I'm not taking any risks. Any bug who talks like that must have some kind of stinker." So the striped bug left. The little bug kept talking. She said, "One time, I made a stink that was so powerful it turned all the grass brown. I'll bet that I can beat ten skunks in a stinking contest." The fattest bug said, "I came here for a stinking meet, not a talking meet. I'm leaving." And he did. The little bug kept talking. Soon another bug left. [1]

Notepad Files

Title	Data
-------	------

To-Do Tasks

Tasks	Data
-------	------

Overview History

Activity	Date	Details
Braillio	09/16/2024	Tweaked settings.
Typio-BRL	09/16/2024	Did a mini review.
Typio	04/30/2024	Practiced typing.
Arcade	04/16/2024	Played Wizard's Tower.
Arcade	04/16/2024	Played FutureBot.
Arcade	04/16/2024	Played Canteen.
Arcade	04/16/2024	Played Samurai Easy.
Typio	04/09/2024	Hatched their Typing Pet.
Typio	04/09/2024	Continued their Typing Journey.